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Raising a Bilingual Child

What the research says · Ages 0–5

Many Indian children grow up hearing two or three languages. That's a strength, not a problem.

What the research says

- Learning two languages from early childhood is natural; bilingual children reach language milestones within the normal range (Byers-Heinlein & Lew-Williams, 2013).
- UNESCO recommends that children learn in a language they understand, especially in the early years (UNESCO, 2016).

Myths and facts

- Myth: Two languages confuse children. Fact: Children learn to separate languages naturally.
- Myth: Mixing languages is a sign of confusion. Fact: It's a normal, clever strategy.
- Myth: Speak only English to help school. Fact: Rich talk in any language builds the skills they need.

Everyday tips

- Each adult can speak their strongest language
- Read, sing and tell stories in your home language
- Keep talking even if they answer in English
- Visit grandparents and relatives who speak the language

When to check

If your child isn't using words by about 16 months, or isn't combining words by 2, speak to your paediatrician, whatever the number of languages.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Byers-Heinlein, K., & Lew-Williams, C. (2013). Bilingualism in the early years: What the science says. LEARNing Landscapes, 7(1), 95–112.
UNESCO (2016). If you don't understand, how can you learn? Global Education Monitoring Report, Policy Paper 24.

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